

A LONG WAIT FOR JUSTICE

- **Jan 18-21:** Wrestlers begin protest against WFI chief Brij Bhushan at Jantar Mantar, call it off after assurances
- **Jan. 23:** Five-member oversight committee formed
- **Apr. 23:** Unhappy with progress, wrestlers return to Jantar Mantar
- **Apr. 28:** Two FIRs registered against Brij Bhushan after Supreme Court's intervention
- **Jun. 15:** Police file chargesheet
- **Aug. 23:** World body suspends WFI for delay in holding elections
- **Dec. 21-26:** Brij Bhushan's aide elected WFI chief; Sakshi calls it quits; Bajrang returns Padma Shri; sports ministry suspends new WFI team; Vinesh returns Khel Ratna/Arjuna awards



AFP

BLOOD, TOIL, TEARS... (L-R) Bajrang, Sakshi and Vinesh being detained during a protest, May 28

Tokyo Olympic bronze medallist Bajrang Punia and Asian Games gold medallist Vinesh Phogat. The next day, stopped from proceeding towards the Prime Minister's residence, Bajrang left his Padma Shri on Kartavya Path—a thought as poignant as it is ironic. Then, on December 26, like a coda to a heroic epic writ in tragic tones, came Vinesh's open letter to the PM saying she was returning her Khel Ratna and Arjuna awards.

Together, they formed something like a triumvirate of protest, gaining a poster-like iconicity and lending one of the strongest strands to the story of 2023, as they went at a Goliath by the name of Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, bossman of the Wrestling Federation of India (WFI) and six-time Lok Sabha MP from Uttar Pradesh. Who won? For the most part, it seemed the immovable object had held out against the unstoppable force. Past his eligible time, Brij Bhushan replaced himself with his handpicked proxy, Sanjay Singh. Celebratory scenes erupted at his bungalow in New Delhi, the de facto WFI HQ during his 12-year tenure. The placards put up by his supporters stung more: "*Dabdaba tha, dabdaba rahega*"...loosely suggesting, the bazooka was ours, and will stay ours.

That victory proved short-lived, with public sentiment playing referee and the sports ministry suspending the new committee. But it will be a long battle—for those in the ring, for India's female athletes in general, for gender justice and the rule of decency. That no woman was elected to the 15-member WFI committee was further proof of how entrenched gender disparity is in the sport. The future also appears bleak for a sport that has given India six medals in the last four Olympics. For now, the WFI remains suspended at the international level. And India's finest grapplers, instead of preparing for the Paris 2024 trials, were fighting on the streets. Here they had rallied, slept and trained for 40 days. In between, as they were dragged by policemen, the images of India's most decorated athletes in agony stunned the nation, made world headlines and gave us a watershed 2023 moment. ■